The Wizard of Oz: The Screenplay

By Noel Langley, Florence Ryerson and Edgar Allan Woolf

INTRODUCTION

*I offer for your viewing pleasure today, my rendition of The Wizard of Oz in less than ten minutes! No, seriously . . . I can do it! I had to leave out a few parts . . . like . . . The munchkins (all those little buggers do is sing!), the poppy field (who wants to watch us sleep?). . . . the flying monkeys (we can flap, but certainly can't fly) and I had to cut down the Wizard's long-winded speech toward the end (let's face it . . . he talked **forever**!). So . . . . We start our adventure just after Dorothy and Toto make a crash landing in Oz, compliments of Tornado Alley in Kansas! The Wizard of Oz: The Screenplay by Noel Langley, Florence Ryerson and Edgar Allan Woolf.*

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DOROTHY: *(exits her farmhouse, looking around with an expression of delighted amazement.)* Toto, I've a feeling we're not in Kansas anymore ... We must be over the rainbow! *Suddenly a large, pink-tinted crystal BUBBLE approaches. The WITCH OF THE NORTH APPEARS from the bubble. (astounded . . . to TOTO)* Now I - I know we're not in Kansas.

GLINDA: *(comes gracefully forward.)* Are you a good witch - or a bad witch? *DOROTHY is so sure GLINDA can't be addressing her that she looks around behind her.*

DOROTHY: *(turning back)* Who, *me?* Why - I'm not a witch at all. I'm Dorothy Gale from Kansas.

GLINDA: *(puzzled)* Well, I'm a little muddled - the Munchkins called me because a new witch has just dropped a house on the Wicked Witch of the East – and there's the house – and here you are – and that's all that's left of the Wicked Witch of the East. *(Glinda points to two ruby slippers attached to the crushed legs of the WW of the E)* And so: Are you a good witch or a bad witch?

DOROTHY: Oh, but I've already told you, I'm not a witch at all – witches are old and ugly.

GLINDA: *(smiling)* I am a witch. I'm Glinda, the Witch of the North.

DOROTHY: You are? *(curtsies)* Oh, I beg your pardon! But I've never heard of a beautiful witch before!

GLINDA: Only bad witches are ugly. *(there is a terrific EXPLOSION, leaving the WITCH OF THE WEST. DOROTHY Terrified, hugs TOTO close to her. THE WICKED WITCH walks over to the farmhouse to look at the WICKED WITCH OF THE EAST.*

DOROTHY: *(in alarm and bewilderment)* I thought you said she was dead!

GLINDA: That was her sister, the Wicked Witch of the East. This is the wicked Witch of the West. And she's worse than the other one was.

WITCH: *(turning to Glinda and Dorothy)* Who killed my sister? Who killed the Witch of the East? *(to DOROTHY)* Was it you?

DOROTHY: *(fearfully)* No, No! It was an accident - I didn't mean to kill anybody!

GLINDA: *(quickly)* Aren't you forgetting the ruby slippers?

WITCH: The slippers - yes, the slippers! *(She hurries to the house and is just about to snatch up the slippers when they vanish from under her hands and the feet shrivel up under the house.)* They're gone! The ruby slippers - what have you done with them? Give them back to me or I'll - *(turning back to GLINDA)*

GLINDA: It's too late! *(She points her wand at DOROTHY's feet)* There they are, and there they'll stay!

WITCH: *(to both GLINDA and DOROTHY, in a frenzy)* Give me back my slippers! I'm the only one that knows how to use them - they're of no use to you!

GLINDA: *(to DOROTHY)* Keep tight inside of them - their magic must be very powerful, or she wouldn't want them so badly! *(laughs) (to WW of W)* You have no power here! Be gone before somebody drops a house on you, too!

WITCH: *(falling back as she looks up)* Very well - I'll bide my time - *(to DOROTHY)* - but I'll get you, my pretty, and your little dog, too - *(with a burst of laughter, she whirls around and vanishes in a burst of smoke and fire and a clap of thunder.*

GLINDA: *(to DOROTHY)* I'm afraid you've made rather a bad enemy of the Wicked

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Witch of the West. The sooner you get out of Oz altogether, the safer you'll sleep, my dear.

DOROTHY: Oh, I'd give anything to get out of Oz altogether; but which is the way back to Kansas? I can't go the way I came -

GLINDA: No, that's true. The only person who might know would be the great and wonderful Wizard of Oz himself. He lives in the Emerald City. *(kisses her on forehead)* All you do is follow the Yellow Brick Road. *(pointing with wand)*

(She steps back, and the large pink-tinted crystal BUBBLE reappears. The bubble slowly rises, carrying GLIDA away) DOROTHY skips down the Yellow Brick Road. She stops as the Yellow Brick Road crosses another one. She looks up and down, puzzled.

DOROTHY: Follow the Yellow Brick Road, follow the Yellow - Now which way do we go?

VOICE: Pardon me. That way is a very nice way. *He is hanging awkwardly on the pole, with his arm pointing to the right down the road.*

DOROTHY: Who said that? *She looks around for the voice. TOTO barks at the SCARECROW. Don't be silly, Toto.* Scarecrows don't talk.

SCARECROW: *(pointing to the left)* It's pleasant down that way too.

DOROTHY: Why, you did say something, didn't you? *The SCARECROW shakes his head, then stops and nods it instead.* Are you doing that on purpose - or can't you make up your mind?

SCARECROW: That's the trouble. I can't make up my mind. I haven't got a brain - only straw. *(showing her)*

DOROTHY: How can you talk if you haven't got a brain?

SCARECROW: I don't know. But some people without brains do an awful lot of talking.

DOROTHY: *(speculatively)* Yes - I guess you're right. *(impressed by such a truth)* Well, we haven't really met properly, have we? *(curtsying)* How do you do?

SCARECROW: Oh, I'm not feeling at all well. You see, it's very tedious being stuck up here all day long with a pole up your back.

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DOROTHY: Oh, dear! That must be terribly uncomfortable. Well, here - let me help you! *(puzzled - as she works)* Well, oh, dear - I don't quite see how I can - *(bending down the nail)* Oh yes!

SCARECROW: *(as he slips off to the ground)* Ohhh! *(As he lands, his coat bursts open, and straw falls out from his abdomen.)* Whoops! *(laughs)* There goes some of me again! *(He stuffs the straw back into is coat. He gets up and stretches himself luxuriously)* My! It's good to be free! *(He whirls around and promptly falls over a broken fence rail)*

DOROTHY: Oh! *(screams)* Ohhh! Oh!

SCARECROW: *(sitting up with a hopeful smile)* Did I scare you?

DOROTHY: No, no. I – I just thought you hurt yourself.

SCARECROW: But I didn't scare you . . . ? *(dolefully)* I didn't think so. *(A crow lights on his shoulder at this moment)* Boo! Scat! Boo! *(The crow picks a piece of straw and flies off with it.) (To Dorothy)* You see, I can't even scare a crow! *(almost weeps)* Oh, I'm a failure, because I haven't got a brain.

DOROTHY: Well, what would you do with a brain if you had one?

SCARECROW: Do? Why if I had a brain I could – *(goes into his song and amusing dance)*

I could while away the hours
Conferrin' with the flowers
Consultin' with the rain
Any my head, I'd be scratchin'
While my thoughts were busy hatchin'
If I only had a brain. - Whoa!

At the finish, he falls to the road. DOROTHY picks up some of his straw and rushes over to him to stuff it back in again.

DOROTHY: Wonderful! *(shaking his hand)* Why, if our scarecrow back in Kansas could do that, the crows'd be scared to pieces!

SCARECROW: Where's Kansas?

DOROTHY: That's where I live. And I want to get back there so badly, I'm going all the way to Emerald City to get the Wizard of Oz to help me.

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SCARECROW: *(with a sudden idea)* Do you think if I went with you, this Wizard would give me some brains? *(pleading)* Uh . . . won't you take me with you?

DOROTHY: *(warmly)* Why, of course, I will!

SCARECROW: *(leaping into the air)* Hooray! We're off to see a Wizard! *(they continue down the Yellow Brick Road, arm in arm)*

The two continue down the Yellow Brick Road until they come to the TIN MAN'S LITTLE COTTAGE – Dorothy takes a break to gather up some apples and falls on her hands and knees to pick one up. She sees a tin foot just beside it. She raps on it and then looks up, and sees the TIN MAN. She scrambles to her feet, examining him.

DOROTHY: *(raps on him)* Why, it's a man! A man made out of tin! *(she raps on his chest) A creaky, rusty sound comes from the TIN MAN.*

TIN MAN: *(almost inaudibly)* Oil can! Oil can!

DOROTHY: He said oil can! Oil can? Oh! Oh! *(finding oil can)* Here it is! Where do you want to be oiled first?

TIN MAN: My mouth . . . my mouth! *DOROTHY sends a drop or tow by the TIN MAN's mouth (clearing s throat, as his joints squeak)* M - m - my, my, my, my, my, my goodness! I can talk again! Oh, oil my arms, please! Oil my elbows! Oh! Oh!

DOROTHY: *(she starts working on his arm joints)* Here. *(Lowering his ax)* Goodness! How did you ever get like this?

TIN MAN: Oh, well, 'bout a year ago, I was chopping that tree, when suddenly it began to rain. And right in the middle of a chop, I - I rusted solid. I've been that way ever since. Oh. *As he talks, DOROTHY is working his joints.*

DOROTHY: Well, you're perfect now.

TIN MAN: Perfect? Oh, bang on my chest if you think I'm perfect. Go ahead - bang on it! *DOROTHY raps on his chest, which echoes.* It's empty. *(He looks around, then lowers his voice as telling a terrible secret.)* The tinsmith forgot to give me a heart. All hollow! *(He bangs on his chest and knocks himself against a tree stump. Dorothy goes to help him, but he holds her off) (singing)*

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When a man's an empty kettle
He should be on his mettle
And yet, I'm torn apart
Just because I'm presumin'
That I could be kind-a human
If I only had a heart.

He goes into a dance. Just as he finishes, the TIN MAN's joints lock, and DOROTHY comes over to help. The TIN MAN staggers back and lands on a tree stump).

DOROTHY: . . . oh, oh, oh, are you all right?

TIN MAN: I'm afraid I'm a little rusty yet. Oh!

DOROTHY: Oh, dear. That was wonderful! You know, we were just wondering why you couldn't come with us to the Emerald City to ask the Wizard of Oz for a heart!

TIN MAN: Well, suppose the Wizard wouldn't give me one when we got there?

DOROTHY: Oh, but he will *(in distress)* He must! We've come such a long way already -

SCARECROW: *(offering his arm to DOROTHY)* To Oz!

TIN MAN: *(offering his arm to her)* To Oz!

LAP DISSOLVE TO: LONG SHOT – DARK AND EERIE FOREST The comrades are coming along the Yellow Brick Road. They move forward slowly and stop.

DOROTHY: Oh, I don't like this forest! It's - it's dark and creepy! Do - do you suppose we'll meet any wild animals?

TIN MAN: Mmm – we might. Mostly lions and tigers and bears.

DOROTHY: Oh my! *A roar from ahead of them.*

LONG SHOT - COWARDLY LION in the distance roars. He advances; Dorothy retreats. He leaps in the air and comes down on all fours. He straightens up in a boxer's stance and then waltzes menacingly, doing some very fancy shadow boxing.

LION: *(growling)* Hah, put 'em up, put 'em up! Which one of ya is first? I'll fight ya both together if ya want. I'll fight ya with one paw tied behind my back. *(puts paw behind back)* I'll fight ya standin' on one foot! *(stands on one foot)* I'll fight ya with my eyes closed. *(closes his eyes, then opens them - to TIN MAN)* Ohhhh - pull in' an ax on me,

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eh? *(to SCARECROW)* Sneakin' up on me, eh? Why . . . *(growls) CLOSE SHOT - TOTO barking* I'll get you anyway, peewee! *(qrowls) (TOTO jumps into the bushes with the LION growling after him. DOROTHY grabs TOTO in her arms. She slaps the LION smartly on the nose.)*

DOROTHY: Shame on you -

LION: *(bawling)* What did ya do that for? I didn't bite him -

DOROTHY: No, but you ***tried*** to!

LION: *(sniffing pathetically)* Well, ya didn't have to go and hit me, did ya? *(sobbing)*

DOROTHY: *(severely)* My goodness, what a fuss you're making - why, you're nothing but a great big coward!

LION: *(to DOROTHY, with great self-pity, playing with his tail)* You're right, I **am** a coward! I haven't any courage at all! I even scare myself.

DOROTHY: Why don't you come along with us? We're on our way to see the Wizard now. I'm sure he could give you some courage -

LION: *(still sniffling)* Gee, that - that's awfully nice of ya. My life has been simply unbearable. *(emotionally as they walk)* It - It's been in me so long, I just gotta tell ya how I feel. *(singing)*

If I were King of the Forest,
Not Queen, not Duke, not Prince.
My regal robes of the forest
would be satin, not cotton, not chintz.
I'd commend each thing, be it fish or fowl,
With a woof and a woof, and a royal growl – woof. *Dorothy bows*

DOROTHY: Your Majesty, if you were King. You wouldn't be afraid of anything? Supposin' you met an elephant!

LION: I'd wrap him up in cellophant. How? . . . . Courage! What makes a king out of a slave! . . . Courage! What makes the flag on the mast to wave! . . . Courage! What makes the elephant charge his tusk in the misty mist or the dusky dusk? What

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makes the muskrat guard his musk? . . . Courage! What have they got that I ain't got?

ALL (DOROTHY): Courage!

LION: You can say that again! Ha, ha - huh?

TRANSITION

Blah, blah, blah . . . sleeping in the poppy field . . . blah, blah, blah . . . And then the quartet of adventurers arrive in Oz and are granted an audience with the Wizard.

(Actor 2 plays Oz's Voice and should be positioned facing the back of the room directly behind Dorothy, who faces judge)

OZ'S VOICE: I am Oz, the Great and Powerful! Who are you? Who are you?

DOROTHY: I - if you please, I am Dorothy, the Small and Meek. We've come to ask you -

OZ'S VOICE: *(booming forth and interrupting)* SILENCE! The Great and powerful Oz knows why you have come! Tin Man! You dare to come to me for a heart - do you? You clinking, clanking, collection of junk! And you, Scarecrow, have the effrontery to ask for a brain? You billowing bale of bovine fodder! And you, Lion!

(Actor 2 steps out to play the part of the Lion) The LION groans with fear as he is slowly pushed forward. CLOSE ON LION He begins to speak and faints dead away. (Actor 2 resumes position as Wizard)

DOROTHY: *DOROTHY straightens up from LION and turns on WIZARD. (angrily)* Oh - oh! You ought to be ashamed of yourself! Frightening him like that, when he came to you for help!

OZ'S VOICE: Silence, whippersnapper! The beneficent Oz has every intention of granting your requests! But first you must prove yourselves worthy by performing a very small task. Bring me the broomstick of the Witch of the West! Now go!

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TRANSITION

Piece of cake right? Well, the Wicked Witch had the band of Flying Monkeys, see, who captured Dorothy and Toto, shredded the Scarecrow, beat some major dents into the Tin Man and scared the Lion so bad he wet himself. But through sheer perseverance, loyalty and commitment, the friends make their way to the Witch's castle to rescue Dorothy. Success! Almost . . . on the way out of the fortress, their great escape goes a bit south!

WITCH: *(laughing)* Well! Ring-around-the-rosy! A pocketful of spears! Thought you'd be pretty foxy, didn't cha? Well, the last to go will see the first three go before her . . *She grins and looks up, then lifts her broom to a burning torch on the wall.* How about a little fire, Scarecrow! *The WITCH thrusts the blazing broom at the SCARECROW. It sets his arm on fire.*

SCARECROW: *(jumping up and down)* Oh! No! No! *(DOROTHY screams)* Help! I'm burning! I'm burning! I'm burning. Help! Help! Help! Help! *(In defense of the SCARECROW, DOROTHY looks around and suddenly sees a bucket of water.).*

WITCH: *(screaming)* Don't touch that water! *DOROTHY flings its contents toward the SCARECROW. The water hits her full in the face and puts out the fire. She screams in agony as she shrinks and shrivels.)* Ohhh! You cursed brat! Look what you've done! I'm melting! Melting! You destroy(ed) my beautiful wickedness! Ohhhh – ohhhhhh - ohhhh!

DOROTHY: *(looking around at the Witch's minions, the WINKIES)* I didn't mean to kill her - really I didn't . . . it's . . . it's just that he was on fire! *(to the leader of the WINKIES)* The broom! May we have it? *(Accepts the broomstick)*

TRANSITION

And so the band of battle-weary travelers make their way back to the chamber of the Great Oz, who they discover is really a very good man, but a very bad wizard. From a large, black magician's back, he presents the Scarecrow with a diploma in honor of his brains, a ticking heart-shaped clock for the Tin Man as a symbol of his humanity and he awards the Lion a Triple-Cross Medal for his courage. But for Dorothy . . . who only wants to go home . . .

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DOROTHY: *(Sadly)* I don't think there's anything in that black bag for me.

SCARECROW: *(pointing)* Look! Here's someone who can help you! *The WITCH OF THE NORTH'S BUBBLE comes to rest and fades. GLINDA approaches, waving her wand.*

DOROTHY: *(curtsying)* Oh, will you help me? Can you help me?

GLINDA: You don't need to be helped any longer. You've always had the power to go back to Kansas. [You] wouldn't have believed me. [You] had to learn it for [yourself].

TIN MAN: What have you learned, Dorothy?

DOROTHY: *(thoughtfully)* Well, I . . . I think it's that if I ever go looking for my heart' s desire again, I won't look any further than my own backyard; because if it isn't there, I never really lost it to begin with! *(timidly to GLINDA)* Is that right?

GLINDA: *(nodding and smiling)* That's all it is. Now those magic slippers will take you home in two seconds! Are you ready now?

DOROTHY: Yes, I'm ready now.

GLINDA: Then close your eyes and tap your heels together three times . . . . . and think to yourself, "There's no place like home; there's no place like home; there's no . . . "

DOROTHY: *(DOROTHY speaks with her eyes closed while clicking her heels)* " . . . there's no place like home; there's no place like home . . . there's no place like home; there's no place like home . . . "

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Noel Langley, Florence Ryerson and Edgar Allan Woolf
ISBN: 978-1566933018
Publisher: OSP Publishing, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1994

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier